COLUMBIA
VAGELOS INSTITUTE FOR BASIC BIOMEDICAL SCIENCE
BIOMEDICAL RESEARCH EDUCATION

Instructions for Completing the Application

- Online Application
- $110 Application Fee
- Personal Statement (500-1,000 words recommended)
- 3 Letters of Recommendation from academic sources (online)
- Transcripts (unofficial copies uploaded with application)

For an expeditious review of your application, we require that all materials be submitted online. Unofficial copies of transcripts must be uploaded as part of the online application and official copies will be required for accepted students. All tests should be taken at least six weeks before the application deadline to ensure timely receipt by the admissions office. Additional supporting materials should be submitted as they become available. Supporting documents will not be accepted after the deadline date. All documents become the property of Columbia University and cannot be returned. Please visit our website for application guidelines and Q&A.

Note that applicants must submit all materials directly, not through an agent or third-party vendor, with the following exceptions: submissions by the US Department of State's Fulbright Program and its three partner agencies IIE, LASPAU and AMIDEAST; submissions by the Danish-American Fulbright Commission (DAF); and submissions by Deutscher Akademischer Austauschdienst (DAAD). In addition, applicants are required to attest to the accuracy and authenticity of all information and documents submitted to Columbia. If you have any questions about this requirement, please contact the Vagelos Institute PhD Pathway (BiomedicalSciences@cumc.columbia.edu).

We require that the work contained in your application (including Personal Statement) is completely accurate and exclusively your own. Columbia University permits the use of generative AI tools for idea generation and/or to edit a candidate's work; however, using these tools to generate complete responses violates the Honor Code.

Failure to submit complete, accurate, and authentic application documents consistent with these instructions may result in denial or revocation of admission, cancellation of academic credit, suspension, expulsion, or eventual revocation of degree. Applicants may be required to assist admissions staff and faculty involved in admission reviews in the verification of all documents and statements made in documents submitted by students as part of the application review process.

Additionally, the applicant has an obligation to update their application, from the point of submission until enrollment at the University, of any material changes to their application, including change in standing at any academic institution (includes current school, even if it is another Columbia University program) due to academic or behavior issues. If the application asks for information about criminal history, then any pending criminal charges or subsequent convictions would also be material changes.

Fall Term/Full-time

All PhD programs at the Columbia University Vagelos College of Physicians and Surgeons are full-time programs, and entrance is only in the fall term. Applications should be submitted by **December 1, 2026**. The application portal will be closed at **5:00 PM EST**. The Biomedical Informatics program also offers a terminal MA degree. You may use this application for that program as well.

Application Fee

The $110 nonrefundable application fee can be paid by credit card at the time of application. Once submitted, your application fee is not refundable, with the exception when duplicate payment is made for the same application for the same admissions cycle. Applications are not considered complete and will not be reviewed until the fee is paid and the application is submitted. Our programs will waive the application fee for: (1) applicants who demonstrate financial need or personal hardship; and (2) applicants who are currently serving in the US military. Please email your request to BiomedicalSciences@cumc.columbia.edu **before you submit**

your application with materials to support your request, such as letters from your university, tax returns, or other financial documents. *Important: under no circumstances should you include your Social Security Number in any of the documents submitted via this form. If your Social Security Number or other sensitive, personal information appears on any of your financial materials, please redact before submitting.*

Personal Statement

A Personal Statement is a 500-1,000-word (recommended) essay explaining your academical and career goal, relevant research or work history, and why you want to attend Columbia and a specific program/track.

Transcripts

Please upload a copy of your unofficial transcripts with the online application. If you are currently in school, please submit an updated transcript reflecting fall 2026 grades as soon as available. All documents not issued in English by the official signing them must be accompanied by English translations. Official copies of transcripts will be requested for **accepted** students only. Please visit our website for instructions for submission of transcripts when accepting an offer of admission.

Letters of Recommendation

Three letters of recommendation from academic sources are required. Letters should be from your most recent instructors or research mentors in your proposed field of study. If you have been out of school, one letter should be from your employer, supervisor, or person familiar with your most recent activities. If you have attended another graduate school, one letter must be from the graduate instructor/mentor most familiar with your work. Letters should be submitted online. If this presents a problem, please contact our office. The email address for each recommender should be a professional email address (e.g., with an ".edu" extension or company-related domain). If such an email address is not possible, the student must provide an explanation and seek permission from this office to utilize a non-professional email address for the reference. Recommenders should be encouraged to include in their letters: their relationship to the applicant; the duration of their relationship; and as many specifics regarding their experience as possible (for example, a former instructor might name the course that the applicant took with them, the applicant's performance in the class, ranking of the applicant against other students taught, etc.). Applicants should not participate in the drafting of letter(s) of recommendation. The IP address from which the recommendation is submitted must be different from the IP address from which the application is submitted. If this is not the case, the letter will be verified as submitted by the recommender and/or the applicant must supply a new letter.

Graduate Record Examination (GRE)

General and Advanced (Subject) GRE scores are **not** required by any of our programs/tracks, although you may submit them if you apply.

If you choose to submit General GRE and/or Advanced (Subject) GRE scores, they should be no more than five years old. Our institution code is 2619. No department code is required.

English Proficiency Requirement

Applicants whose undergraduate degree was awarded by an institution in a country where English is **not the sole official language** must complete the English proficiency requirement. **The English proficiency requirement is based on the official language of the country in which the undergraduate (or Bachelor's) degree was earned, regardless of an applicant's citizenship.** The English proficiency requirement can be fulfilled through:

- The Test of English as a Foreign Language (TOEFL) or the International English Language Testing System (IELTS). For TOEFL, our School Code is 2619. A **minimum TOEFL score of 100** on the internet-based test or **a 7.5 for the IELTS** is required for **all** admitted applicants. TOEFL and IELTS scores are valid for two years after the test date. We accept the "MyBest" scores reporting option offered by TOEFL(iBT). You may use the results of tests taken on various dates to achieve the minimum score requirement. ***If an applicant's score is below the above minimum, the application won't be reviewed.***
- Students who have earned a Master's degree, but not an undergraduate or Bachelor's degree, in the US or another country whose sole official language is English are required to complete the English proficiency

requirement; however, if you took the TOEFL or IELTS exam when applying to a graduate program at another institute and scored above the **minimum requirement of 100 (TOEFL) or 7.5 (IELTS)**, you may fulfill the English proficiency requirement by uploading **a scanned copy of your old score report** to the online application.

- If you earned your undergraduate degree in a country where the official language is not English, but the official language of instruction at your institution is English, you may request a waiver of the English proficiency requirement to BiomedicalSciences@cumc.columbia.edu with a letter from your university.

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https://www.vagelos.columbia.edu/education/academic-programs/vagelos-institutes-biomedical-research-education-phd-programs